Clear assessment instructions and criteria

Are assessment instructions and criteria clear?

LANGUAGE / ASSESSMENT

ONE-PAGE TEACHING GUIDE

WHAT IS IT?

Clear language is used in instructions, criteria, and feedback, with key terms explained

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

University contains many hidden rules: what “critical analysis” means, what a rubric is really asking for, when it is acceptable to ask for help, or what counts as “professional” behaviour. If those rules remain unspoken, familiarity can be mistaken for capability.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “Everyone else seems to know rules nobody has explained.”
- “I understand the topic, but not what I am being asked to do.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Write instructions in plain, direct language without losing disciplinary precision.
- Explain key assessment terms and link them to criteria.
- Check that feedback points to a next move rather than restating the criterion label.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A task sheet breaks the assignment into steps and defines key terms like “analyse” and “synthesise” with brief examples.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

For this assessment, we aim to write assessment instructions and criteria in clear language and explain key terms. The learning outcomes being assessed are [insert outcomes].

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Creating and using rubrics

Feedback for learning

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